4.1 Colonial Army Forms

You nervously count and recount your bullets as you and your fellow militiamen stand at the top of the hill. Below, a line of red-coated British soldiers marches toward you, pausing only to fire in unison. This is it. This is war.

MAIN IDEA Colonial leaders remained reluctant to fully declare independence, but battles between the British and colonial militias continued to break out.



CRITICAL VIEWING Originally built by the French in 1755, Fort Ticonderoga was constructed to guard a strategic strip of land that connected New France and the American colonies. What do you observe about the fort's location that may have been significant during the American Revolution?

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VICTORY AT FORT TICONDEROGA

The next battle in the growing conflict took place on May 10, 1775. At dawn that morning, **Ethan Allen**, a Patriot and colonial leader from Vermont, and **Benedict Arnold**, from Connecticut, led a troop of militia in an attack on Fort Ticonderoga in northeastern New York. In a classic example of "timing is everything," the militia known as the Green Mountain Boys surprised the sleeping British soldiers and captured the fort without firing a shot.

The victory at Fort Ticonderoga gave the colonial forces an important advantage. The Green Mountain Boys captured the fort's **artillery**, or large guns that could fire a long distance. In all, they claimed 59 cannons and 19 other pieces of heavy artillery for the colonies. It was an epic gain.

On the same day that Ethan Allen took Fort Ticonderoga, the **Second Continental Congress** met in Philadelphia. Many of the delegates had also been part of the First Continental Congress. New delegates included Thomas Jefferson of Virginia and Benjamin Franklin of Pennsylvania.

The Congress recognized the need to prepare for war and wanted to make sure the army would be under its control. So it appointed **George Washington** as the commander in chief of the colonial forces, which would now be called the **Continental Army**. Despite this warlike decision, however, many of the delegates were still opposed to declaring independence.

BATTLE OF BUNKER HILL

Before Washington could even take command of the troops, another battle broke out. The militia around Boston learned that the British were planning to seize the hills overlooking the city. On June 16, a troop of militiamen occupied Bunker Hill and Breed's Hill to prevent the British from taking the high ground.

The next morning, the British troops attacked. The militia fighters were greatly outnumbered. They were also short of ammunition, so they had to make every shot count. Colonel William Prescott, their commander, is said to have told his men, "Don't fire until you can see the whites of their eyes."



An American Traitor

Benedict Arnold was an early hero in the American Revolution who went on to become one of the most infamous traitors in American history. After helping capture Fort Ticonderoga in 1775, Arnold continued his support of the American war efforts but felt his work went unrecognized. In 1779, he secretly negotiated with the British to turn over an American post in exchange for a commanding position in the British army and a cash reward. Arnold's plot was discovered by the Americans, but he escaped to British territory.

The militia did have one key advantage: the British troops had to charge uphill to reach them. The redcoats tried storming Breed's Hill three times. The first two attempts failed, resulting in a huge loss of lives. On the third try, the Patriots were overrun by the redcoats. Britain won the battle, but at an enormous cost. Today, the encounter is known as the Battle of Bunker Hill, even though most of the fighting took place on Breed's Hill.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What happened at the battles of Fort Ticonderoga and Bunker Hill?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** Why did the Second Continental Congress decide to prepare for war?
3. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** Do you think peace between Britain and the colonies could have been possible in 1775? Why or why not?

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